

understanding of covetousness is almost biblical in proportion, and toy companies are masters at tapping into that primal vice.)

But my grandmother was right. Once the fancy wrapper was off and I'd put my very plain plane together, it was really just a few bits of boring wood. The toy I was going to show off and share was nothing more than a flimsy, badly constructed trinket. It barely flew. You might think it was a little mean for Grandma to burst my bubble like that, but it became a monumental moment in my life. It was the first time I made a direct correlation between money and value.

Like any kid, I had always attached feelings to the money I spent on toys or candy. I'd see something I wanted. I'd feel sad because I didn't have it. Then I'd buy it and feel happy because I finally had what I wanted. Then the toy broke, the candy was eaten, or I got bored, only to start at the beginning again. Who doesn't cycle through that consumer thought process, child or adult? The entire advertising industry is built on putting consumers in a trance. But here was my old Lebanese grandmother breaking that spell.

I began to look at where a product was made. I considered the packaging. Kids want and buy a lot of junk. From the moment my grandmother questioned my purchase, she planted a seed in my brain, one that no longer allowed me to buy another thing in my life without asking myself these questions: Is it any good? Will it last? Where did it come from? Kids understand when something's junky. They know about crappy fast food, so teach them about cheaply made goods. If it's flimsy and built to break, tell them that. Tell them it's a waste of money, and you don't waste money. This entire lesson is undermined if you promise to buy them a cheaper version of what they want, a common parental consumer trap. If anything, you want to teach them to bargain up. Offer to pay for a portion of a better-quality item, one that will last longer and do more, if they can save up for their part. You work out the percentages based on your financial situation, but kids need to feel that transaction personally so that they can attach value to the money spent, not just to the purchased product.

Because kids eat a lot and grow fast, the majority of your money is spent on food and clothes. It usually comes out of the parent's pocket. Money for toys and games, anything you deem extra, should